The Brazilian Speaker's Error Guide

Companion to **File 1 (3-Month Program)**. These are the mistakes Portuguese speakers make most, with the fix and a quick drill for each. **Teacher tip:** don't teach this as a list. Use it to *recognize* errors during free talk, then pick the 3–5 that matter most for each student.

1. Pronunciation — the "Big 8"

#	Problem	What Brazilians do	Fix	Drill
1	**Extra "i" at the end**	*big-i, like-i, Facebook-i, hot-dog-i*	Stop the sound. Close the mouth / hold the tongue.	*big, book, like, stop, good, work, nice, Brazil*
2	**TH**	*"tank you"*, *"fank you"*, *"sree"*	Tongue lightly between the teeth, blow air	*think, three, thank, Thursday, third, mouth · the, this, that, mother*
3	**Initial R / H**	*rice → "hice"*; *hotel → "rotel"* (with Portuguese R)	English R: tongue curled back, doesn't touch anything. English H: just soft air	*red/head, rice, right, Rio · house, hotel, happy, help*
4	**Final -ED**	*work-ed, play-ed, ask-ed*	3 sounds: /t/ worked · /d/ played · /id/ only after t/d: wanted, needed	*I asked, I liked, I stopped · I called, I stayed · I visited, I waited*
5	**Vowel length**	*ship = sheep, live = leave, full = fool*	Long vowels are LONG and tense; short ones relaxed	*sit/seat, live/leave, fill/feel, pull/pool · beach, sheet, piece* (keep long!)
6	**Final M / N**	*"time"* sounds like *"taym"*, *"I'm"* like *"aim"* nasal	Close the lips for M, touch tongue on top for N	*time, name, home, come · ten, fine, phone, train*
7	**Initial S + consonant**	*"es-tudent"*, *"es-pain"*, *"es-tarbucks"*	Start directly with S — no "e" before	*student, Spain, Starbucks, school, stop, speak, small*
8	**Final L**	*"Brazil" → "Braziu"*, *"hotel" → "hoteu"*	Tongue touches behind the top teeth at the end	*Brazil, hotel, call, feel, people, little*

Also: word stress (*HO-tel* × → *ho-TEL*; *de-VE-lop*; *COM-for-ta-ble* = "COMF-ter-bul"); "I" sound in English is often "ai" (*idea = ai-DI-a*), and many silent letters (*walk, talk, half, Wednesday, listen, island*).

2. False friends (falsos cognatos) — the dangerous ones

English word	Means	NOT	Portuguese meaning → English
actually	na verdade	atualmente	→ *currently / nowadays*
eventually	finalmente, com o tempo	eventualmente	→ *occasionally*
pretend	fingir	pretender	→ *intend / plan*
push	empurrar	puxar	→ *pull*
parents	pai e mãe	parentes	→ *relatives*
library	biblioteca	livraria	→ *bookstore*
lunch	almoço	lanche	→ *snack*
exquisite	requintado, refinado	esquisito	→ *weird / strange*
college	faculdade	colégio	→ *(high) school*
attend	frequentar, comparecer	atender	→ *answer (phone) / serve (customer)*
assist	ajudar	assistir	→ *watch*
realize	perceber	realizar	→ *achieve / accomplish*
sensible	sensato	sensível	→ *sensitive*
constipated	com intestino preso	constipado (resfriado)	→ *have a cold / congested*
injury	ferimento	injúria	→ *insult*
novel	romance (livro)	novela	→ *soap opera*
fabric	tecido	fábrica	→ *factory*
legend	lenda / legenda de mapa	legenda (de filme)	→ *subtitles*
costume	fantasia	costume	→ *habit / custom*
prejudice	preconceito	prejuízo	→ *loss / damage*
support	apoiar	suportar	→ *stand / tolerate*

English word	Means	NOT	Portuguese meaning → English
lecture	palestra	leitura	→ *reading*
resume (verb)	retomar	resumir	→ *summarize*
comprehensive	abrangente, completo	compreensivo	→ *understanding*
intend	ter intenção	entender	→ *understand*
exit	saída	êxito	→ *success*

3. "Translated" sentences — the grammar traps

❌ Brazilian translation	✅ Natural English	Note
I have 60 years.	**I'm 60.** / I'm 60 years old.	Age uses BE
I am agree.	**I agree.**	Agree is a verb
I'm with hunger / cold / headache.	**I'm hungry / cold. I have a headache.**	
Do you want that I help you?	**Do you want me to help you?**	
She said me…	**She told me… / She said (that)…**	tell + person
I lost the bus / the flight.	**I missed the bus / my flight.**	
I'm going to make a question.	**I'd like to ask a question.**	ask a question
I made a party / a trip.	**I had a party. I took a trip.**	
People is nice.	**People are nice.**	People = plural
I live here since 2010.	**I've lived here since 2010.**	Teach as chunk
It depends of…	**It depends on…**	
I'm thinking in going.	**I'm thinking about going.**	
Explain me…	**Explain to me… / Can you explain…?**	
I need go. / I want go.	**I need to go. / I want to go.**	
He don't like…	**He doesn't like…**	3rd person
Is very beautiful.	**It's very beautiful.**	English needs a subject

❌ Brazilian translation	✅ Natural English	Note
Have many people here.	**There are a lot of people here.**	"Tem" = there is/are
I stayed in the house.	**I stayed home / at home.**	
Do you like to have a coffee?	**Would you like a coffee?**	invitation
How do you call this?	**What do you call this?** / How do you say…?	
I'm boring.	**I'm bored.**	"boring" = chato (causes)
What means ___?	**What does ___ mean?**	question order
Where is the bathroom? (US)	**Where's the restroom?**	works, but restroom is more natural in public places
I want a beer.	**Could I get a beer, please?**	"I want" can sound rude

4. Conversation habits (cultural)

- **Too direct requests** ("Give me…", "I want…") → soften with *Could I…? / Can I get…? / I'd like…*. In English, politeness lives in the grammar.
- **Too long answers to officials** → in immigration and interviews, short and direct. Brazilians tend to explain too much when nervous.
- **Not saying "please", "thank you", "sorry", "excuse me"** often enough — English speakers use them constantly.
- **Interrupting / speaking at the same time** — normal in Brazil, can seem rude in the US/UK. Practice waiting for the end of the sentence.
- **Physical closeness / touching** — in many English-speaking countries, people keep more distance with strangers.
- **"Yes" when you didn't understand** — the most dangerous habit. Always: *"Sorry, could you repeat that?"*